Multi-Omic Analysis v2 (alt. pathway)

Antoine Chaillon

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1. Multi-Omic Normalization of the HIV Signature

Data Harmonization & Subsetting Logic

To isolate the long-term impact of cannabis on the inflammatory "milieu," transcriptomic analysis was restricted to **Vehicle-treated MDM samples** ($n = 36$). This ensures that the observed signatures reflect the donor's historical in vivo exposure rather than acute ex vivo stimulation. Proteomic data was derived from matching donor plasma ($n = 26$).

For multi-omic validation, MDM transcripts were mapped to plasma proteins using a one-to-many Ensembl-to-Symbol relational map, with multiple transcripts for a single symbol collapsed to the mean:

$$\bar{x}_{\text{Symbol}} = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n} \text{ENSEMBL}_i$$

1.1 Establishing the Basal HIV Signature

To understand how cannabis modulates the macrophage environment, we first established the "Basal HIV Signature." This was defined by comparing HIV+ and HIV- donors who were both cannabis-naive, using only the Vehicle-treated samples ($n = 10$).

The signature is characterized by significant upregulation in TNFα Signaling, Macrophage Activation, and Neuroinflammation (table 1 below).

> **Note**
>
> Here I am using pathways identified with 'Molecular Signatures Database' (MSigDB) and driven by initial Claude report.

1.2 Defined Pathways of Interest

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Gene Count	Gene List	Pathway
97	ADAR, B2M, BATF2, BST2, C1S, CASP1, CASP8, CCRL2, CD47, CD74, CMPK2, CMTR1, CNP, CSF1, CXCL10, CXCL11, DDX60, DHX58, EIF2AK2, ELF1, EPSTI1, GBP2, GBP4, GMPR, HELZ2, HERC6, HLA-C, IFI27, IFI30, IFI35, IFI44, IFI44L, IFIH1, IFIT2, IFIT3, IFITM1, IFITM2, IFITM3, IL15, IL4R, IL7, IRF1, IRF2, IRF7, IRF9, ISG15, ISG20, LAMP3, LAP3, LGALS3BP, LPAR6, LY6E, MOV10, MVB12A, MX1, NCOA7, NMI, NUB1, OAS1, OASL, OGFR, PARP12, PARP14, PARP9, PLSCR1, PNPT1, PROCR, PSMA3, PSMB8, PSMB9, PSME1, PSME2, RIPK2, RNF31, RSAD2, RTP4, SAMD9, SAMD9L, SELL, SLC25A28, SP110, STAT2, TAP1, TDRD7, TENT5A, TMEM140, TRAFD1, TRIM14, TRIM21, TRIM25, TRIM26, TRIM5, TXNIP, UBA7, UBE2L6, USP18, WARS1	IFN-a/b
201	ABCB7, ACAA1, ACAA2, ACADM, ACADSB, ACADVL, ACAT1, ACO2, AFG3L2, AIFM1, ALAS1, ALDH6A1, ATP1B1, ATP5F1A, ATP5F1B, ATP5F1C, ATP5F1D, ATP5F1E, ATP5MC1, ATP5MC2, ATP5MC3, ATP5ME, ATP5MF, ATP5MG, ATP5PB, ATP5PD, ATP5PF, ATP5PO, ATP6AP1, ATP6V0B, ATP6V0C, ATP6V0E1, ATP6V1C1, ATP6V1D, ATP6V1E1, ATP6V1F, ATP6V1G1, ATP6V1H, BAX, BCKDHA, BDH2, CASP7, COX10, COX11, COX15, COX17, COX4I1, COX5A, COX5B, COX6A1, COX6B1, COX6C, COX7A2, COX7A2L, COX7B, COX7C, COX8A, CPT1A, CS, CYB5A, CYB5R3, CYC1, CYCS, DECR1, DLAT, DLD, DLST, ECH1, ECHS1, ECI1, ETFA, ETFB, ETFDH, FDX1, FH, FXN, GLUD1, GOT2, GPI, GPX4, GRPEL1, HADHA, HADHB, HCCS, HSD17B10, HSPA9, HTRA2, IDH1, IDH2, IDH3A, IDH3B, IDH3G, IMMT, ISCA1, ISCU, LDHA, LDHB, LRPPRC, MAOB, MDH1, MDH2, MFN2, MGST3, MPC1, MRPL11, MRPL15, MRPL34, MRPL35, MRPS11, MRPS12, MRPS15, MRPS22, MRPS30, MTRF1, MTRR, MTX2, NDUFA1, NDUFA2, NDUFA3, NDUFA4, NDUFA5, NDUFA6, NDUFA7, NDUFA8, NDUFA9, NDUFAB1, NDUFB1, NDUFB2, NDUFB3, NDUFB4, NDUFB5, NDUFB6, NDUFB7, NDUFB8, NDUFC1, NDUFC2, NDUFS1, NDUFS2, NDUFS3, NDUFS4, NDUFS6, NDUFS7, NDUFS8, NDUFV1, NDUFV2, NNT, NQO2, OAT, OGDH, OPA1, OXA1L, PDHA1, PDHB, PDHX, PDK4, PDP1, PHB2, PHYH, PMPCA, POLR2F, POR, PRDX3, RETSAT, RHOT1, RHOT2, SDHA, SDHB, SDHC, SDHD,	Oxidative Phosphorylation

1.2 The Transcriptomic "Sign-Flip": Normalizing the HIV Environment

Cannabis-Induced Normalization

We then evaluated the effect of historical cannabis exposure (Moderate, Daily, and Combined "Any User") on these specific basal pathways. We observed a nearly universal "sign-flip," where pathways natively upregulated by HIV were significantly suppressed in cannabis users

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Pathway	Basal HIV (Naive)	Moderate vs Naive	Daily vs Naive	Any User vs Naive
IFN-a/b	1.81 (<0.001)	-0.75 (0.98)	-1.7 (<0.001)	-1.62 (<0.001)
Oxidative Phosphorylation	1.33 (0.02)	-1.7 (0.02)	-1.75 (<0.001)	-2.69 (<0.001)
Complement System	1.23 (0.08)	0.84 (0.84)	-1 (0.47)	-1.11 (0.23)
TNFa Signaling	2.35 (<0.001)	-2.49 (0.02)	-2.54 (<0.001)	-2.52 (<0.001)
NLRP3 Inflammasome	1.59 (0.04)	-1.67 (0.03)	-1.31 (0.16)	-1.73 (0.01)
Neuroinflammation	1.96 (<0.001)	-2 (0.01)	-1.4 (0.10)	-1.7 (0.01)
Macrophage Activation	2.29 (<0.001)	-2.41 (<0.001)	-1.88 (<0.001)	-2.11 (<0.001)
Endocannabinoid	1.29 (0.18)	-0.9 (0.57)	-1.06 (0.40)	-1.16 (0.29)

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This table highlights the primary pathways upregulated in the HIV+ basal state (Blue columns) alongside their corresponding enrichment in cannabis users (Red columns). Data represents Normalized Enrichment Scores (NES) with associated p-values. A negative NES in the cannabis column represents a shift toward the transcriptional profile of an HIV-negative donor.

Global Transcriptomic Normalization Map

A comparison of the HIV Disease Signature (x-axis; HIV+ Naive vs HIV- Naive) against the Cannabis Treatment Effect (y-axis; HIV+ User vs HIV+ Naive). Pathways situated in the bottom-right quadrant represent biological processes induced by HIV infection that are subsequently suppressed by cannabis exposure. The dotted red line ($y = -x$) represents an ideal "perfect reversal."

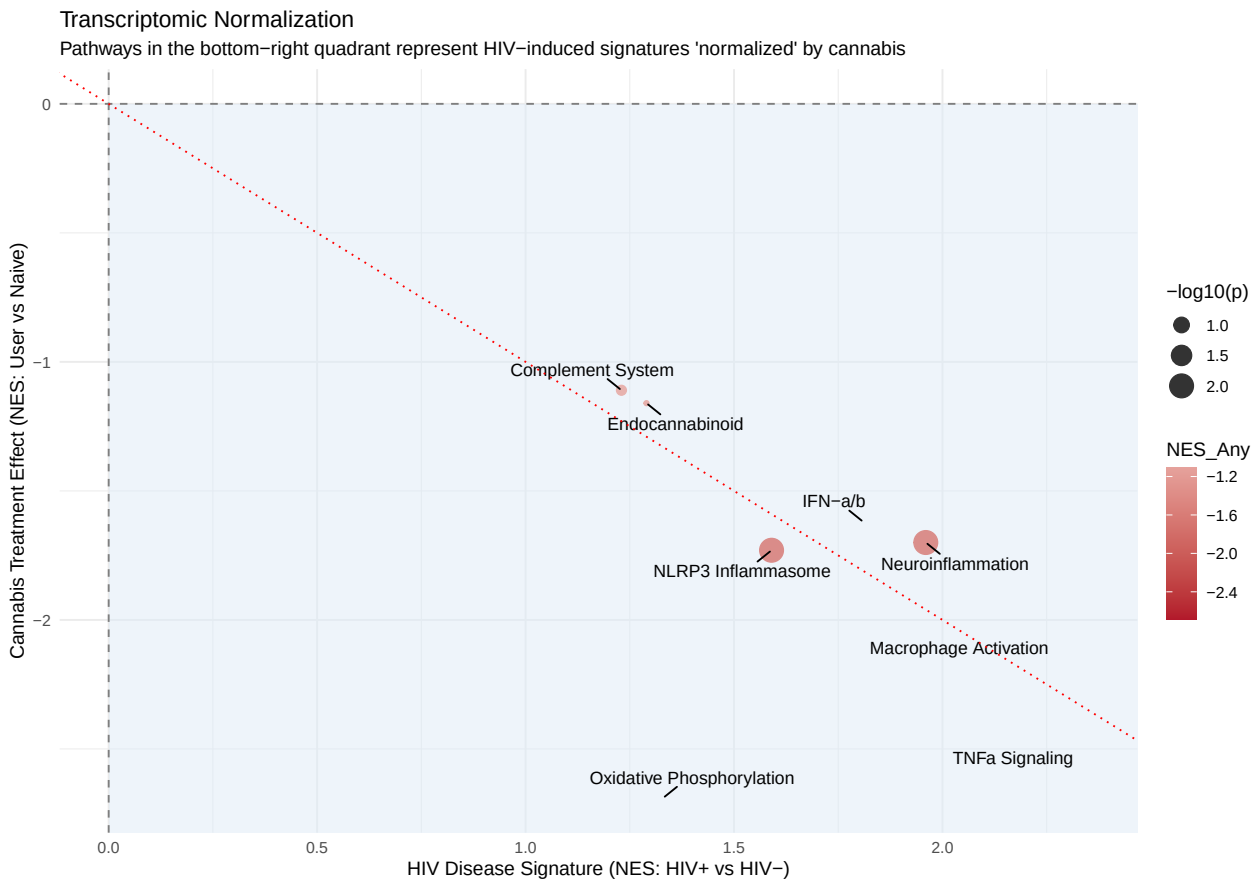

Figure 1: The Transcriptomic 'Sign-Flip'. Comparison of HIV-induced pathway enrichment (x-axis) versus Cannabis-induced suppression (y-axis).

The size of each point corresponds to the statistical significance of the cannabis-mediated suppression ($-log10(p)$).

1.3 Multi-Omic Validation: From Source to System

To verify that the transcriptomic suppression observed in our ex vivo MDM model reflects the systemic inflammatory state of the patients, we correlated the MDM RNA expression with the donors' circulating plasma protein levels.

Statistical Approach

The "Source-to-System" concordance was calculated using Pearson's correlation coefficient (r) for lead-edge genes identified in the GSEA. For genes with multiple transcripts, we utilized the mean expression value (see equation above).

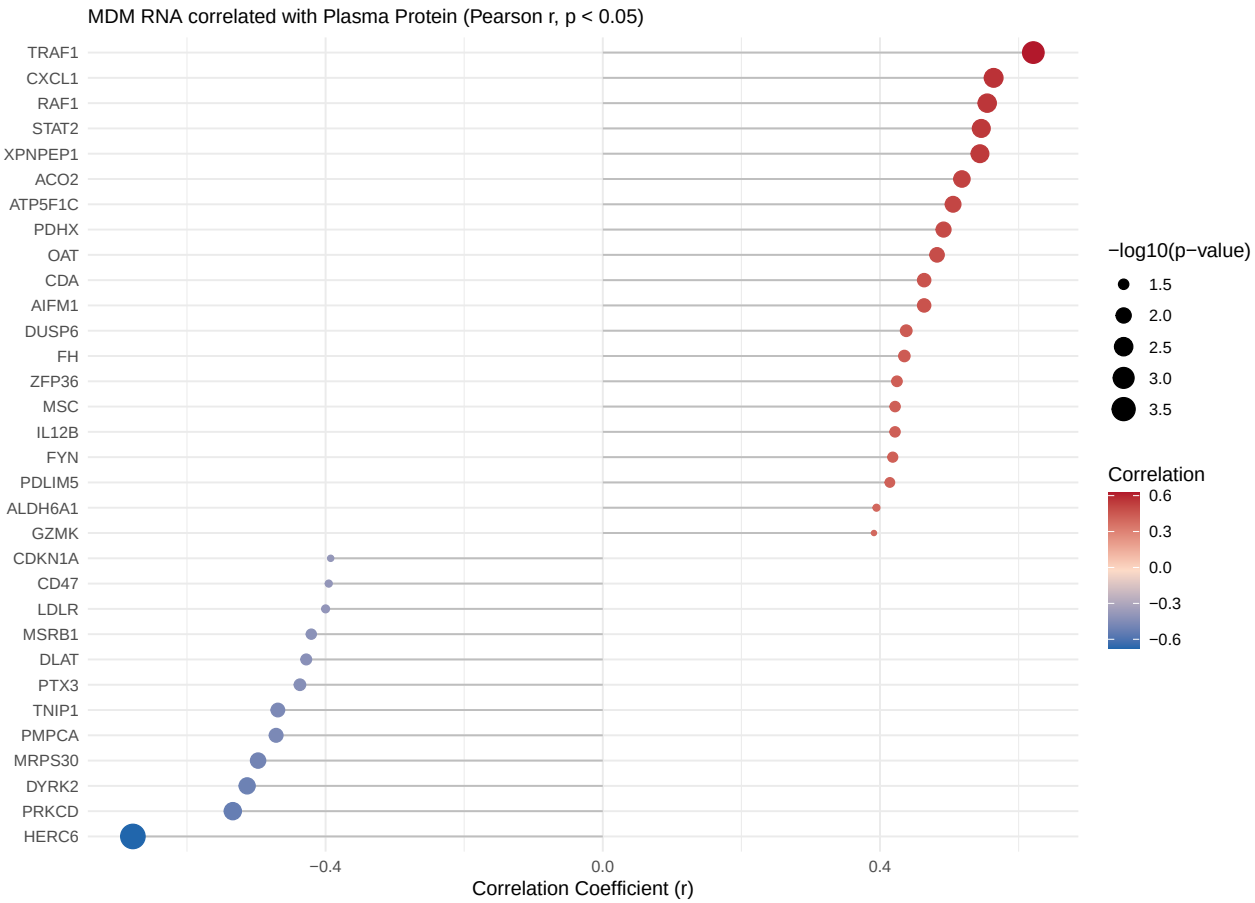

Figure 2: Validated Source-to-System Markers. Points represent genes where MDM RNA significantly correlates ($p < 0.05$) with systemic plasma protein levels.

1.4 Biological Proof-of-Concept: The TRAF1/TNF Axis

As a representative example of this normalization, TRAF1 (a key mediator of the TNFα signaling pathway) showed both high transcriptomic reversal ($NES = -2.4$) and a strong systemic correlation ($r = 0.62$).

In the plasma, we observe a significant reduction in TRAF1 protein levels in both Moderate and Daily cannabis users compared to Naive HIV+ donors.

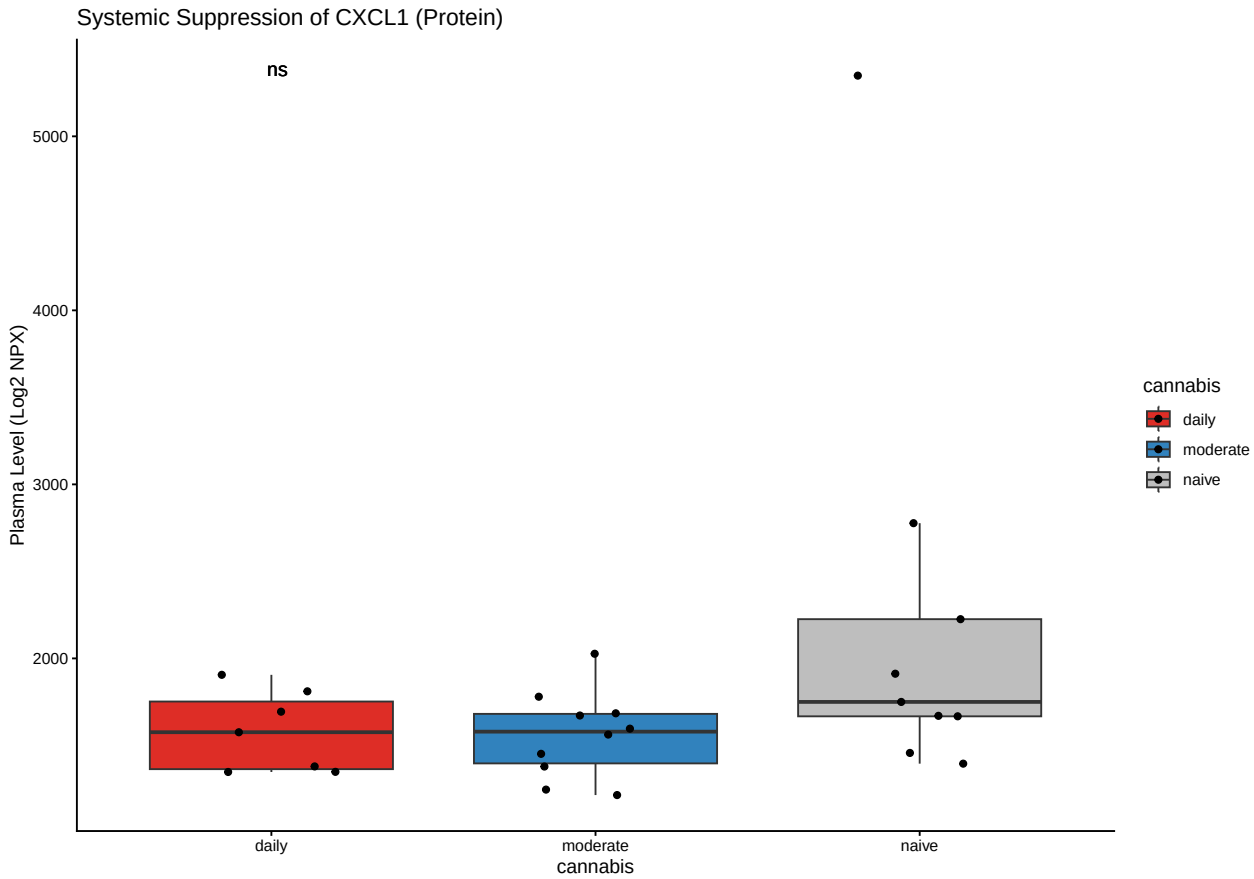

Figure 3: Systemic Suppression of CXCL1 Protein. Plasma levels were measured via Proteomics.

1.5 Summary of Multi-Omic Concordance

The following table summarizes the markers that successfully bridge the cellular and systemic datasets.

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Pathway	Validated Marker	Correlation (r)	p-value (Omic)	Cannabis Reversal (NES)
Complement System	CXCL1	**0.5639797685600911**	0.002692866581074779	**-1.111404281884721**
Complement System	RAF1	**0.554690104145945**	0.003272904720440877	**-1.111404281884721**
Complement System	XPNPEP1	**0.5442310881849468**	0.004050112879449548	**-1.111404281884721**
Complement System	CDA	**0.4636990481097986**	0.01703359806280476	**-1.111404281884721**
Complement System	DUSP6	**0.4378482915451456**	0.02527923021088186	**-1.111404281884721**
Complement System	FYN	**0.4183782660047498**	0.03341376859641081	**-1.111404281884721**
Complement System	GZMK	**0.3912977223858731**	0.04807175615469587	**-1.111404281884721**
Complement System	MSRB1	**-0.4206490215155101**	0.03236917086348194	**-1.111404281884721**
Complement System	DYRK2	**-0.5131943025162523**	0.007336446774258825	**-1.111404281884721**
Complement System	PRKCD	**-0.5338974709927045**	0.00496649081901055	**-1.111404281884721**
IFN-a/b	STAT2	**0.546141558920013**	0.003897483906588752	**-1.624470407687546**
IFN-a/b	CD47	**-0.3954425784863289**	0.04554858247667291	**-1.624470407687546**
IFN-a/b	HERC6	**-0.6780756723270563**	0.0001408998492864396	**-1.624470407687546**
Oxidative Phosphorylation	ACO2	**0.5181752670507004**	0.006693718204129322	**-2.68607705828104**
Oxidative Phosphorylation	ATP5F1C	**0.5054264404510375**	0.008441693169235794	**-2.68607705828104**

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Correlation (r) indicates the strength of the relationship between MDM cellular activity and patient blood levels. Cannabis Reversal (NES) indicates the magnitude of pathway suppression in HIV+ cannabis users; negative values (Blue) represent a shift toward a “normal” (HIV-negative) transcriptomic state.

2. Altered Cellular Responsiveness

The goal here is to determine if a macrophage from a cannabis user is "primed" differently, making it more or less responsive to inflammatory stimuli (IL1B) or cannabinoids (THC/CBD) added in the lab.

2.1 Conserved Transcriptional Program Following Acute IL-1 Challenge

To determine if chronic cannabis exposure results in "myeloid exhaustion" or altered sensitivity, we analyzed the acute response to inflammatory (IL-1) and cannabinoid (THC, CBD) stimuli using a Likelihood Ratio Test (LRT).

We first analyzed the "Activation Potential" of MDMs by stimulating them with IL-1 . We modeled the response within each donor group to see if the magnitude of inflammatory induction differs.The response is defined by the log2 fold change (LFC) of gene expression (G) under stimulation (stim) compared to the vehicle (veh):

$$\text{LFC_IL1B} = \log_2(G_\text{stim}) - \log_2(G_\text{veh})$$

Key Finding: Functional Competence is Maintained. While chronic cannabis exposure normalizes the basal inflammatory state (Section 3), it is critical to determine if this results in "immune paralysis." We utilized a Likelihood Ratio Test (LRT) to identify genes with divergent responses to acute IL-1 stimulation.

The absence of genes reaching global significance ($FDR < 0.05$) indicates that the "Transcriptomic Normalization" associated with cannabis use does not result in myeloid exhaustion or a blunted capacity to respond to acute stimuli.

Figure 3 demonstrates a high degree of concordance in the activation programs across all donor groups. The tight alignment along the $y = x$ diagonal proves that the primary activation pathways remain functionally intact, regardless of historical cannabis exposure.

2.2 Divergence in Regulatory and Adhesion Markers

While the core inflammatory program remained stable, a subset of genes showed nominal evidence of differential responsiveness ($p < 0.01$). Notably, ITGA1 (Integrin Alpha-1) and LILRB1 (Leukocyte Immunoglobulin Like Receptor B1) exhibited blunted induction in cannabis users.

The log_2 Fold Change represents the "Interaction Effect." A negative value (e.g., ITGA1: -4.73) indicates that the gene's response to IL-1 was significantly attenuated in cannabis users compared to naive donors.

Table 1: Table 3. Nominally Significant Interaction Markers (IL-1 Response).

SYMBOL	Interaction LFC	p-value	Base Expression
ITGA1	-4.73	0.00340	52.88685301734397
LILRB1	-7.37	0.00380	33.01501120629396
EBI3	0.13	0.00607	461.6751254246932
ZNF43	0.07	0.00787	6.35758882309237

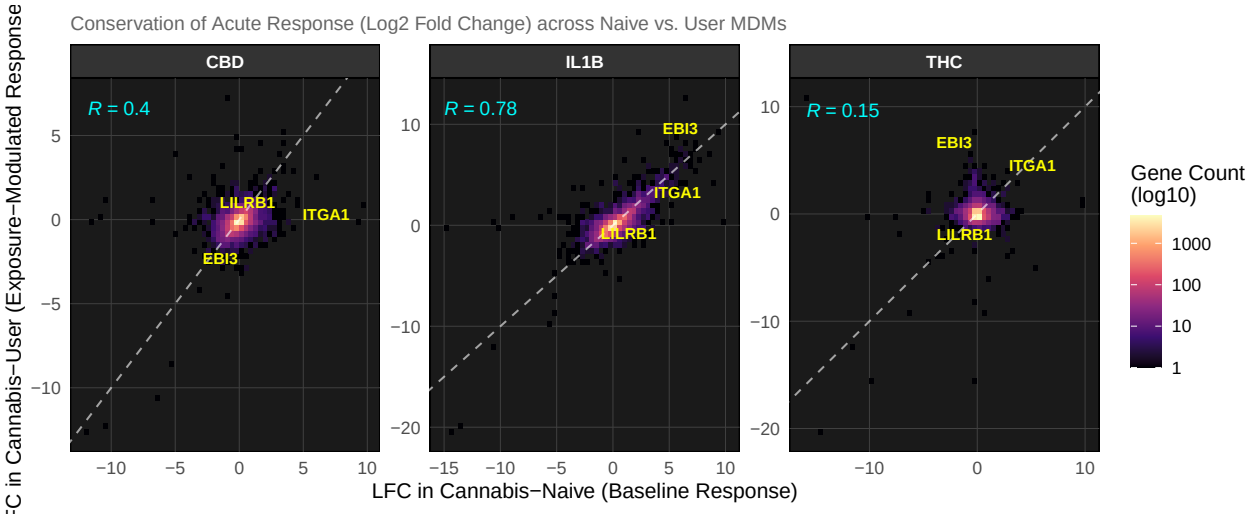

Figure 4: Multi-Stimuli Response Concordance. Comparison of acute transcriptional induction (Log2 Fold Change) between Cannabis-Naive and Cannabis-User MDMs across three acute challenges. The tight correlation along the diagonal demonstrates that the primary activation machinery is preserved despite chronic exposure.

2.3 Visualizing Global Response Conservation

2.4 Acute Sensitivity to Cannabinoids (THC & CBD)

Now, we apply the same logic to THC and CBD. We want to know: Do the macrophages of daily users "care" less when you give them THC in the dish?

The "Tolerance" Hypothesis: If chronic users are desensitized, we expect to see a "blunted" diagonal in the concordance plot (a slope < 1) or a large cluster of genes with significant interaction terms.

Acute Stimulation	Interaction Hits (p < 0.01)	Biological Interpretation
IL-1β	**4**	*Conserved Inflammatory Competence*
THC	**4**	*Minimal Receptor Desensitization*
CBD	**4**	*Consistent Anti-inflammatory Signaling*

The "Nominal Hits" represent genes where the transcriptional response to acute challenge differed between cannabis users and naive donors at a non-adjusted threshold of $p < 0.01$. The extremely low frequency of such events (4 genes out of ~15,000 tested) indicates that chronic cannabis exposure does not induce significant cellular tolerance or functional exhaustion in macrophages.

Temptative discussion (AI)

In summary, these data define cannabis as a selective homeostatic modulator in the context of HIV: it successfully 'reverses' the chronic disease-associated transcriptome (Section 1) without compromising the innate immune system's capacity to mount an acute response to secondary inflammatory or pharmacological stimuli (Section 2)